

Stage Electrics

PUWER Applicability and Working Procedure Mechanical Inspection Activities

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Status	Draft for technical and H&S review
Scope	PUWER duties that apply to mechanical inspection work only
Important limitation	This is not legal advice and should be checked against Stage Electrics internal procedures, insurance requirements and any client-specific contractual requirements.

1. Purpose and executive summary

This document narrows the Provision and Use of Work Equipment Regulations 1998 (PUWER) to the parts that are relevant to Stage Electrics when planning, carrying out, recording and managing mechanical inspection work. It is deliberately not a general PUWER policy for every item of work equipment used by the company.

PUWER applies broadly to work equipment used at work and to businesses that own, operate, control or provide work equipment. HSE states that PUWER requires equipment to be suitable, maintained in a safe condition, inspected where required, used by trained people and supported by appropriate safeguards, markings, controls and isolation arrangements. [S1]

For mechanical inspection work, the central PUWER question is whether the item is work equipment whose safety depends on installation, assembly, condition, deterioration, modification, damage or other circumstances that could create a dangerous situation. Where that applies, inspection arrangements must be risk-based, competent, recorded and linked to a clear decision on whether the equipment can remain in service. [S2], [S3]

Where the equipment is lifting equipment or lifting accessories, LOLER will normally set the statutory thorough examination regime. PUWER still remains relevant to suitability, maintenance, training, guarding, controls, isolation and safe use, but PUWER Regulation 6 inspection requirements do not apply to work equipment for lifting loads, including people. [S4], [S5]

2. Applicability to Stage Electrics mechanical inspection work

2.1 In scope

- Mechanical inspection of work equipment owned, hired, supplied, installed, serviced or controlled by Stage Electrics, where the inspection is required to confirm safe condition for work use.
- Mechanical inspection linked to installation, assembly, reassembly, relocation, deterioration, modification, repair, damage, extended inactivity or change of use.
- Inspection of safety-related mechanical parts and systems necessary for safe operation, including guards, fixings, restraints, brakes, stops, interlocks, structural condition, fasteners, anchorage interfaces and mechanical control features where these affect safe use.
- Mechanical inspections carried out at Stage Electrics premises, client premises, venues, workshops, warehouses, temporary installations and site locations, where Stage Electrics has responsibility for the inspection or provides evidence of inspection.

2.2 Out of scope or not PUWER-led

- **LOLER thorough examination:** Lifting equipment and lifting accessories should be managed under LOLER for statutory thorough examination. PUWER duties still sit alongside LOLER, but this document should not be used as a substitute for a LOLER thorough examination scheme.
- **Electrical inspection and test:** Electrical safety inspection, PAT, fixed wiring and electrical test regimes are outside this document except where mechanical condition affects safe operation.
- **Pure user pre-use checks:** Basic visual checks by users are not the same as a formal PUWER inspection, although they may form part of the safe system of work.
- **Product conformity assessment:** UKCA/CE conformity, declarations and manufacturer instructions must be retained and considered, but this document does not replace supply law compliance.
- **Client statutory duties:** Where the client or venue remains the dutyholder, Stage Electrics inspection outputs should clearly state what was inspected, what was not inspected and who is responsible for actioning findings.

3. PUWER / LOLER decision filter for mechanical inspection jobs

Question	If yes	If no	Stage Electrics action
Is it work equipment used at work?	PUWER applies.	PUWER may not apply, but HSW Act duties may still be relevant.	Record the dutyholder and basis of inspection.
Is it lifting equipment, a lifting accessory or equipment for lifting/lowering loads or people?	LOLER regime required for thorough examination; PUWER remains relevant for wider safe-use duties.	Continue PUWER inspection filter.	Do not issue a PUWER-only inspection report where a LOLER thorough examination is required.
Does safety depend on installation, assembly or reassembly?	Inspect after installation/assembly and before first use or use at new location.	Continue.	Check installation, fixings, alignment, stability, restraints, guards, access, controls and

Is the equipment exposed to deterioration likely to create danger?	Inspect at suitable risk-based intervals.	Formal PUWER inspection may not be necessary; maintenance and pre-use checks may be enough.	isolation. Set interval using risk assessment, manufacturer advice, environment, use intensity and inspection history.
Has an exceptional circumstance occurred?	Inspect before return to service.	Continue existing regime.	Trigger inspection after major repair/modification, suspected damage, overload, impact, abnormal event, long inactivity or change of use.
Will equipment leave Stage Electrics control or be accepted from another undertaking?	Physical evidence of last required inspection should accompany it.	Keep internal record.	Provide report, tag, label, QR link or other traceable evidence suitable to the item.

4. Relevant PUWER duties for mechanical inspection

4.1 Suitability and foreseeable use

Before an item is passed as suitable for use, the inspection decision should consider whether it is constructed or adapted for the intended purpose, the working conditions in which it will be used, and foreseeable health and safety risks from that use. Any restrictions, limitations or special conditions identified during inspection should be stated clearly on the report or certificate. [S1]

4.2 Maintenance and safe condition

PUWER requires work equipment to be maintained in an efficient state, efficient working order and good repair, and any machinery maintenance log must be kept up to date. For Stage Electrics, inspection findings should feed directly into maintenance, quarantine, repair, re-inspection and return-to-service decisions. [S6]

4.3 Inspection under Regulation 6

Regulation 6 inspection is required where safety depends on installation conditions, where equipment is exposed to deterioration likely to create danger, or where exceptional circumstances could have jeopardised safety. The purpose is to confirm correct installation, maintain health and safety conditions, and detect and remedy deterioration in good time. [S2], [S3]

4.4 Training, information and competence

People using, supervising or managing work equipment must receive adequate information, instruction and training. For mechanical inspection work, inspection personnel need sufficient practical and theoretical knowledge to know what to inspect, what defects matter, what action to take and when to escalate. [S1], [S2]

4.5 Guards, controls, isolation and stored energy

Where relevant, the mechanical inspection should verify that dangerous parts are guarded or otherwise controlled, controls are identifiable and safe, and there are suitable means of isolating energy sources, including gravitational, pneumatic, hydraulic, electrical or stored mechanical energy. [S1]

5. Stage Electrics PUWER mechanical inspection workflow

- 1. Confirm the job category:** Identify the equipment, dutyholder, location, intended use, inspection standard, whether the item is lifting equipment, and whether the work is PUWER-led, LOLER-led or mixed.
- 2. Gather information:** Obtain manufacturer instructions, previous inspection records, maintenance history, modification history, defect reports, risk assessment, drawings if needed and client restrictions.
- 3. Decide inspection scope:** Define safety-critical parts, extent of visual inspection, functional checks, measurements, dismantling, testing, access method and limitations.
- 4. Make the area safe:** Control access, isolate hazardous energy, prevent unexpected movement, support suspended or unstable parts, and verify safe working at height arrangements where required.
- 5. Inspect and test:** Inspect only within the competence, authority and safe system of work. Record defects, limitations, tests performed, pass/fail criteria and immediate actions.
- 6. Decide equipment status:** Classify as serviceable, serviceable with limitations, not serviceable/quarantined, or requires LOLER/engineering review before use.
- 7. Record and communicate:** Issue inspection record or report, update asset/maintenance records, tag/label/QR if appropriate, notify responsible person of defects and actions.

8. **8. Review interval:** Set or confirm next inspection interval using risk, environment, use frequency, manufacturer information, defect trends and inspection history.

6. Competence requirements for inspectors

A person determining or carrying out a PUWER mechanical inspection should be competent for the equipment and context. Competence should be evidenced, not assumed from job title alone.

Competence element	Expected evidence	Notes for Stage Electrics
Equipment knowledge	Training record, manufacturer familiarisation, supervised experience	Must understand normal condition, wear points and failure modes.
Inspection method	Approved checklist, procedure, standard or scheme	Must know what to inspect, how to inspect and acceptance criteria.
Risk judgement	Experience, CPD, escalation record	Must know when a defect affects continued safe use.
Authority	Appointment, role description or authorisation matrix	Must be authorised to pass, restrict, quarantine or escalate equipment.
Independence where needed	Segregation from repair work, peer review or external inspection	Especially important where the inspector would otherwise assess their own repair or modification work.
Record discipline	Completed reports, asset updates, clear defect evidence	Inspection should be traceable and auditable.

7. Minimum content of a PUWER mechanical inspection record

HSE guidance states that inspection records do not need a particular format but should contain practical information such as equipment type/model, identification mark, location, date, inspector, faults, actions taken, who faults were reported to and when repairs or necessary action were carried out. [S3]

- Equipment identification: asset number, serial number, description, make/model and location.
- Dutyholder/client and Stage Electrics job reference.
- Reason for inspection: periodic, installation, reassembly, damage, modification, return from hire, post-repair, change of use or other trigger.
- Scope and limitations: what was inspected, what was not accessible, and any assumptions made.
- Method: visual, functional, measurement, dismantling, test, NDT or other method if used.
- Findings: condition, defects, photographs if relevant, risk significance and immediate controls.
- Decision: pass, restricted pass, fail/quarantine, further investigation, repair required, LOLER referral or engineering review.
- Next action: repair, re-inspection, client notification, maintenance log update, tag/label update and next due date.
- Inspector details: name, competence/authorisation, signature or electronic equivalent.

8. Inspection interval guidance

PUWER does not set a universal interval for all mechanical inspections. HSE states that frequency should be determined by risk assessment, considering manufacturer recommendations, industry advice, user experience, environment and inspection history. Intervals can be shortened where deterioration is found or increased where history shows negligible deterioration. [S2], [S3]

Factor	Lower risk indication	Higher risk indication	Effect on interval
Use intensity	Occasional controlled use	Frequent use, hire stock, touring, repeated assembly	Higher use usually shortens interval.
Environment	Indoor dry controlled venue/workshop	Outdoor, damp, coastal, dusty, dirty, public-facing or impact-prone	Harsh environments shorten interval.
Consequence of failure	Minor disruption, low stored energy	Falling objects, crush, entrapment, loss of support, public exposure	Higher consequence shortens interval and may require specialist review.
Condition history	Stable, no recurring defects	Repeated faults, corrosion, deformation, missing parts, poor records	Poor history shortens interval.
Manufacturer advice	Clear benign maintenance regime	Manufacturer specifies checks, tests or replacement limits	Manufacturer requirements should be followed unless justified otherwise.
Changes	No modification or change of use	Modification, repair, suspected overload/damage, long inactivity	Trigger exceptional inspection before use.

9. Defect classification and equipment status

Category	Meaning	Immediate action	Report wording
A - Dangerous / immediate risk	Defect or condition presents immediate or foreseeable serious risk.	Stop use, quarantine, isolate, notify responsible person immediately.	Not safe for use until repaired and re-inspected.
B - Safety significant	Defect could become dangerous if not addressed or if use continues without controls.	Restrict use or set short corrective timescale; consider quarantine.	Use restricted as stated; corrective action required.
C - Minor / monitor	No immediate safety risk but deterioration or missing information should be corrected.	Record, monitor, plan maintenance.	Serviceable; action recommended by stated date.
D - Outside scope	Item, part or duty not inspected or not within PUWER-only scope.	Refer to LOLER, electrical, structural, manufacturer or engineer as needed.	No opinion given on excluded item/part.

10. Physical evidence, tagging and traceability

Where equipment that requires inspection leaves Stage Electrics control, or is accepted from another undertaking, it should have physical evidence that the required inspection has been carried out. For larger items this may be the inspection report; for smaller items, a tagging, colour coding, label or QR system can link the item back to the inspection record. [S2], [S3]

- Every inspected item should be traceable to the inspection record by asset ID, serial number, barcode, QR code or other unique reference.
- Tags should not be used as a substitute for a record where a record is required; they are evidence and a link back to the record.
- If a tag is missing, illegible, out of date or inconsistent with the record, treat the equipment status as unverified until checked.
- Inspection evidence should show date inspected, next due date where relevant, result/status, inspector or company reference and any restrictions.

11. Mechanical inspection checklist template

This template is intended to be tailored to specific equipment types. Remove irrelevant lines and add manufacturer-specific checks before use.

Check area	Pass	Fail	N/A	Comments / evidence
Identification and record match	☐	☐	☐	
Correct equipment for intended use	☐	☐	☐	
Manufacturer instructions available/considered	☐	☐	☐	
Installation/assembly correct	☐	☐	☐	
Structure/frame/body free from damage, corrosion or deformation	☐	☐	☐	
Fixings, pins, clips, bolts, locking devices present and secure	☐	☐	☐	
Guards, covers and barriers present and effective	☐	☐	☐	
Stops, limiters, restraints or safety devices functional	☐	☐	☐	
Brakes, clutches, latches, locks or catches functional where fitted	☐	☐	☐	
Controls labelled, protected and operating correctly	☐	☐	☐	
Isolation method identified and effective	☐	☐	☐	
Stored/gravitational energy controlled during	☐	☐	☐	

inspection				
Wear, play, cracks, sharp edges, trapped points assessed	☐	☐	☐	
Lubrication and maintenance condition acceptable	☐	☐	☐	
Evidence of overload, impact, misuse or unauthorised modification checked	☐	☐	☐	
Access and working position safe for users/maintainers	☐	☐	☐	
Warning labels, SWL/limitations/use restrictions legible where relevant	☐	☐	☐	
Defects classified and communicated	☐	☐	☐	
Equipment status updated/tagged	☐	☐	☐	
Next inspection/maintenance action set	☐	☐	☐	

12. Implementation notes for Stage Electrics

- Create an equipment category matrix identifying which mechanical items are PUWER-led, LOLER-led, electrical-led, structural-led or mixed.
- Link inspection outputs to the asset database and maintenance workflow so that failed items cannot be issued, hired, installed or returned to service by mistake.
- Use controlled checklists for common equipment groups and require inspector notes where a checklist item is marked N/A.
- Define who can set inspection intervals and who can change them.
- Ensure reports distinguish inspection, maintenance, repair, servicing and LOLER thorough examination; avoid ambiguous certificate wording.
- Keep competence records for inspectors and reviewers, including evidence for specialist mechanical equipment.
- Build an escalation route for defects with high consequence, uncertain significance or possible LOLER/structural/engineering implications.

13. Sources referenced

[S1] HSE, Provision and Use of Work Equipment Regulations 1998 (PUWER) - overview. Key duties: suitability, safe condition, inspection, training, guarding, controls, isolation, maintenance and related legislation. Updated 21 November 2024. <https://www.hse.gov.uk/work-equipment-machinery/puwer-overview.htm>

[S2] HSE, Inspection of work equipment. Inspection purpose, triggers, risk-based frequency, competence and records. Updated 29 October 2024. <https://www.hse.gov.uk/work-equipment-machinery/inspection.htm>

[S3] HSE, Safe use of work equipment: PUWER 1998 ACOP and guidance L22, 4th edition. Regulation 6 inspection, records, physical evidence and exclusions. HSE publication page updated 7 August 2025; PDF originally published November 2014 with 2018 amendments. <https://www.hse.gov.uk/pubns/priced/l22.pdf>

[S4] HSE, Lifting Operations and Lifting Equipment Regulations 1998 (LOLER) overview. Relationship between LOLER and PUWER, lifting operation, lifting equipment, marking and thorough examination. Updated 22 January 2026. <https://www.hse.gov.uk/work-equipment-machinery/loler-overview.htm>

[S5] HSE, Thorough examinations and inspections of lifting equipment. Competent person, intervals, reports and defect reporting under LOLER. <https://www.hse.gov.uk/work-equipment-machinery/thorough-examinations-lifting-equipment.htm>

[S6] HSE, Maintenance of work equipment. PUWER maintenance duties and safe maintenance planning. <https://www.hse.gov.uk/work-equipment-machinery/maintenance.htm>

[S7] HSE, Film, theatre and broadcasting industries. HSE sector landing page covering theatre and related entertainment guidance. Updated 16 March 2023. <https://www.hse.gov.uk/entertainment/theatre-tv/index.htm>